

# CLEAN ENERGY WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT

## Breakout Session Summary

Westchester Clean Energy Action Conference



This roundtable convened workforce developers, training organizations, utilities, employers, real estate professionals, and county agencies for a working conversation about why building a clean energy workforce is so difficult, and what it would take to do it at scale. The discussion moved from the basic problem of defining “clean energy,” through career-pathway design, the incentives driving demand, the access gap for disadvantaged communities, and the fragmentation that keeps the ecosystem from working as a whole.

## SESSION PARTICIPANTS

|           |                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Moderator |  <b>Thom Kleiner</b> Executive Director   Westchester Putnam Workforce Development Board |  <b>Angela N Son</b> Founder<br>The Green Launchpad |
|           |  <b>Antuan Cannon</b> Vice President<br>Willdan Energy Solutions                         |  <b>Dwayne Norris</b> Principal<br>Soulful Synergy  |

## 1. THE LANGUAGE BARRIER: DEFINING CLEAN ENERGY

The session opened with a deceptively simple question, “Can you describe what clean energy work is?”, and the panel agreed that the inability to answer it cleanly is itself a root cause of the field’s difficulty. The presenters offered a shared framework: clean energy as four sectors (energy efficiency, energy storage, renewable energy, and clean transportation), each with interchangeable “alternate ego” terms (decarbonization, weatherization, beneficial electrification, transportation electrification) that require near-expert fluency to decode. The problem is not academic, it’s real in the industry. A career-pathway analysis of a larger energy engineering firm found the same job carried six different titles across departments, a legacy of acquisitions never reconciled. If an employer cannot consistently name a role, a workforce developer cannot source for it.

*“Certifications, funding, wraparound support services, soft skills: these are all different pillars of clean energy workforce development that we all need to be conversant in. But because we’re talking different languages from different parties, it’s really hard to have an eye-to-eye conversation.”*

**Angela Son, The Green Launchpad**

## 2. CAREER PATHWAYS, NOT JUST INSTALLER JOBS

A central argument was that clean energy is not a single job but a workflow: outreach and sales, data collection and auditing, incentive and financing administration, project management, permitting and engineering, installation, and operations. The presenters mapped eight job tracks and stressed decoupling the technology from the function: solar, efficiency, and EV all need surveyors, project managers, and salespeople. The field’s historic mistake has been training installers in volume while neglecting the roles that actually generate and close projects. The flip side is opportunity: transferable skills from other industries (project management,

communications, sales) let career-changers and laid-off professionals enter mid-level without “reinventing themselves.”

*“We trained thousands of people for installer jobs, but we didn’t train any salespeople to drive the demand for the product. We didn’t train the financing people to make sure the projects even went to implementation.”*

**Antuan Cannon, Willdan Energy Solutions**

### 3. FOLLOW THE MONEY: INCENTIVES AND DEMAND

On whether the jobs are real and durable, the panel was emphatic: both the “carrots” (incentives, tax credits, subsidized financing) and the “sticks” (Local Law 97 penalties, mandates, fees) are accelerating at once. Presenters described a new incentive cycle (the Energy Efficiency and Building Electrification era), with incentives projected to grow seven- to ten-fold, and weatherization funding alone potentially scaling from roughly \$10 million to as much as \$100 million across Con Edison and National Grid. Energy efficiency dominates the job numbers (roughly five times any other sector) and should precede solar and electrification. The constraint is not demand; it is a skilled workforce and enough capable contractors to absorb the money.

*“We know the work is coming because there’s going to be money out there for people to do the building envelope, the weather stripping, the windows and the doors. If we know the funding is coming and the penalties are there, it’s very hard to imagine the work is not going to be there.”*

**Dwayne Norris, Soulful Synergy**

### 4. ACCESS AND THE TALENT PIPELINE

A recurring thread was the gap between where the opportunity is and who can reach it. High-paying trades (geothermal drilling was cited at \$80,000 to \$150,000 without a four-year degree) have no accredited, registered training program in New York State, even as oil-and-gas drillers migrate away from the work. Several participants argued the pipeline has to start far earlier: introducing clean energy curriculum in middle and high schools, especially in urban districts that have stripped out shop, electrical, and trade programs. New York’s mandate for climate change education beginning in the 2027–28 school year was welcomed as a step in the right direction. The throughline: people cannot pursue careers they have never been shown exist.

### 5. A FRAGMENTED ECOSYSTEM AND THE ROLE OF INDUSTRY

The session closed on the structural problem beneath all the others. Workforce providers described carrying the entire chain themselves, from writing proposals, recruiting, and case-managing barriers to designing curriculum, training, certifying, and then chasing employers, with no centralized home for resources and no consistent mechanism to bring industry to the table. Government funds the work but rarely co-designs it with employers, leaving training that does not always match hiring needs. The presenters pointed to shared infrastructure as part of the fix (a training-resource database and a combined NYSEERDA/Con Edison employer database), alongside a sharper question for the private sector about where it invests beyond government dollars, and how MWBE-, women-, and veteran-owned contractors capture their share of the coming work.

*“The resources and the jobs are there, but matching them with the available job seekers and the training opportunities is not always intuitive, and that’s what we want to build on.”*

**Thom Kleiner, Westchester-Putnam Workforce Development Board**

## KEY TAKEAWAYS

1

There is no shared definition of “clean energy” work. A common framework (four sectors, eight job tracks) is the prerequisite for everything else.

2

Clean energy is not one job. Training only installers puts the cart before the horse; sales, financing, and project management drive whether projects happen at all.

3

Energy efficiency dominates, with roughly five times the jobs of any other sector, and should precede solar and electrification.

4

The money is coming (Local Law 97 penalties plus a 7–10X incentive cycle; weatherization scaling from ~\$10M toward ~\$100M). The bottleneck is skilled workers and contractors, not demand.

5

Access is the unsolved problem: high-paying trades lack local accredited training, and exposure has to begin in middle and high school.

6

Transferable skills matter. Career-changers and laid-off professionals can enter mid-level without starting over.

7

The ecosystem is fragmented. Scaling requires shared training and employer infrastructure, plus real private-sector investment, not government funding alone.